Esson M. Gale — Discourses on Salt and Iron (Yantie lun), Chapters 29–36

The Boneyard is a collection of works left unfinished, unpublished, or unread at their authors' deaths — dry bones in the valley, in Ezekiel's image. Each presentation tells the scholar's story, weighs what survives of his work, and states plainly what completing it would take, so that a book the world never received whole can be met at last. Each of them was one of one. There will never be another like him, and his light will not shine again except through the work he left behind.

A Boneyard dossier — researched and presented by Robert Tilford, Hays, Kansas. Filed 17 October 2026.

Disclosure: prepared with AI assistance — the six subject reviewers named in the index are AI agents, each desk-checked at this desk; all rulings and final decisions are the author's own.

Dedication

To Esson M. Gale, whom the memorial notice in *Political Science Quarterly* remembers as Associate Director-General of China's Salt Administration — the Sinologist who carried the salt-and-iron debate into English as far as chapter XXVIII, where this completion begins.

The author's own terms

The speaker labels are Gale's, adopted by the folder as house convention. The 大夫 is “the Lord Grand Secretary,” Sang Hongyang; the 丞相 is “the Chancellor”; the provincial 賢良 are “the Worthies”; and the 文學 are “the Literati.” The folder's banner states that Gale's chapters were consulted for these conventions as a check, with no Gale wording reproduced.

The story

ChinaKnowledge describes Huan Kuan (early 1st century BCE), a Confucian-trained scholar, as the author of the sixty-chapter report of the court debate of 81 BCE on the state salt and iron monopolies, and states that he sided with the scholars against Sang Hongyang and Chancellor Tian Qianqiu.

The memorial notice in *Political Science Quarterly* records that Esson McDowell Gale was born in Bad Axe, Michigan, on 8 December 1884, and died in Bay City, Michigan, on 15 May 1964. The same notice connects him with the University of Michigan as student, teacher, and administrator, with teaching at the University of California and Northwestern University. It records that he served the Chinese government, becoming Associate Director-General of China's Salt Administration, was three times decorated by that government, and received a Litt.D. from the University of Leiden; it names him a founder member of the Association for Asian Studies and states that he retired in 1955 as Director of Michigan's International Center.

The work and what survives

ChinaKnowledge records that the *Yantie lun* survives entire in sixty chapters, based on the notes of the 81 BCE discussion, with the Tuzhen edition of the Hongzhi period (1488–1505) as the best early print and Wang Liqi's *Yantie lun jiaozhu* a standard commentary.

The bibliography gives Gale's Englishing in two stages: *Discourses on Salt and Iron: A Debate on State Control of Commerce and Industry in Ancient China, Chapters I–XIX* (Leyden: E. J. Brill, 1931), and the article by Gale, Peter A. Boodberg, and T. C. Liu in the *Journal of the North China Branch of the Royal Asiatic Society* 65 (1934), pp. 73–110, which carried the translation through chapter XXVIII.

This project holds less than its folder title promises. The folder is titled for chapters 29–60, but it holds a draft of chapters 29–36 only, in progress; its own closing note says so, adding that chapters 37–60 are to follow, with dedication and front matter in the final fascicle. The chapters present are 29 “Dispelling Insufficiency,” 30 “Relieving Want,” 31 “The Needle and the Stone,” 32 “Removing Narrowness,” 33 “Against Greed,” 34 “Putting Punishment Last,” 35 “Timely Labor,” and 36 “Flood and Drought.” Its banner states that the draft was rendered from the Chinese text, Project Gutenberg No. 26920, was produced with AI assistance, and has not yet had independent scholarly review.

Its English fortunes

Chapters 29–60 have no complete or book-length English translation

found after research; Gale's Englishing stops at chapter XXVIII (1934).

The bound belongs beside it. The searches behind it, run on 16 October 2026 on the work's titles, on Gale's bibliography, and on later-chapter translation, found ChinaKnowledge's entry recording a partial English translation of chapters 1–28 by Gale and no other English version. No WorldCat or union-catalogue sweep was run, no dissertation index was searched, and no passage-level check was made of the monograph literature on Han economic thought, which may render individual later-chapter passages inside its own argument. Such renderings, if any exist, would narrow the claim at passage level without touching the book-length finding.

What completing it would take

Chapters 37–60 remain to be translated: twenty-four chapters beyond this draft. The draft of chapters 29–36 must pass independent scholarly review by a reader of classical Chinese, which the folder's banner says has not yet happened, and must not be quoted as settled until it is done. Its Chinese base must be settled: the folder names Project Gutenberg No. 26920, but that text's lineage against the Tuzhen tradition and Wang Liqi's collation is not pinned. Dedication and front matter, deferred to the final fascicle, must be written, and a passage-level check of the Han-studies monograph literature must precede any wording stronger than the bounded finding above.

Sources

- Project folder: `~/workspace/rare-and-obscure-books/books/gale-salt-and-iron-ch29-60/gale-salt-and-iron-ch29-60.txt`
- PIN: `~/workspace/packages/boneyard-extension/research/PIN-gale.md`
- “In Memoriam,” *Political Science Quarterly*, via Cambridge University Press: https://core-varnish-new.prod.aop.cambridge.org/core/services/aop-cambridge-core/content/view/40FAA7604007BF76489CF61DD5BED4AE/S0003055400081806a.pdf/in-memoriam.pdf
- “Yantielun,” ChinaKnowledge: http://www.chinaknowledge.de/

Literature/Diverse/yantielun.html

- Gale bibliography: https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Discourses_on_Salt_and_Iron